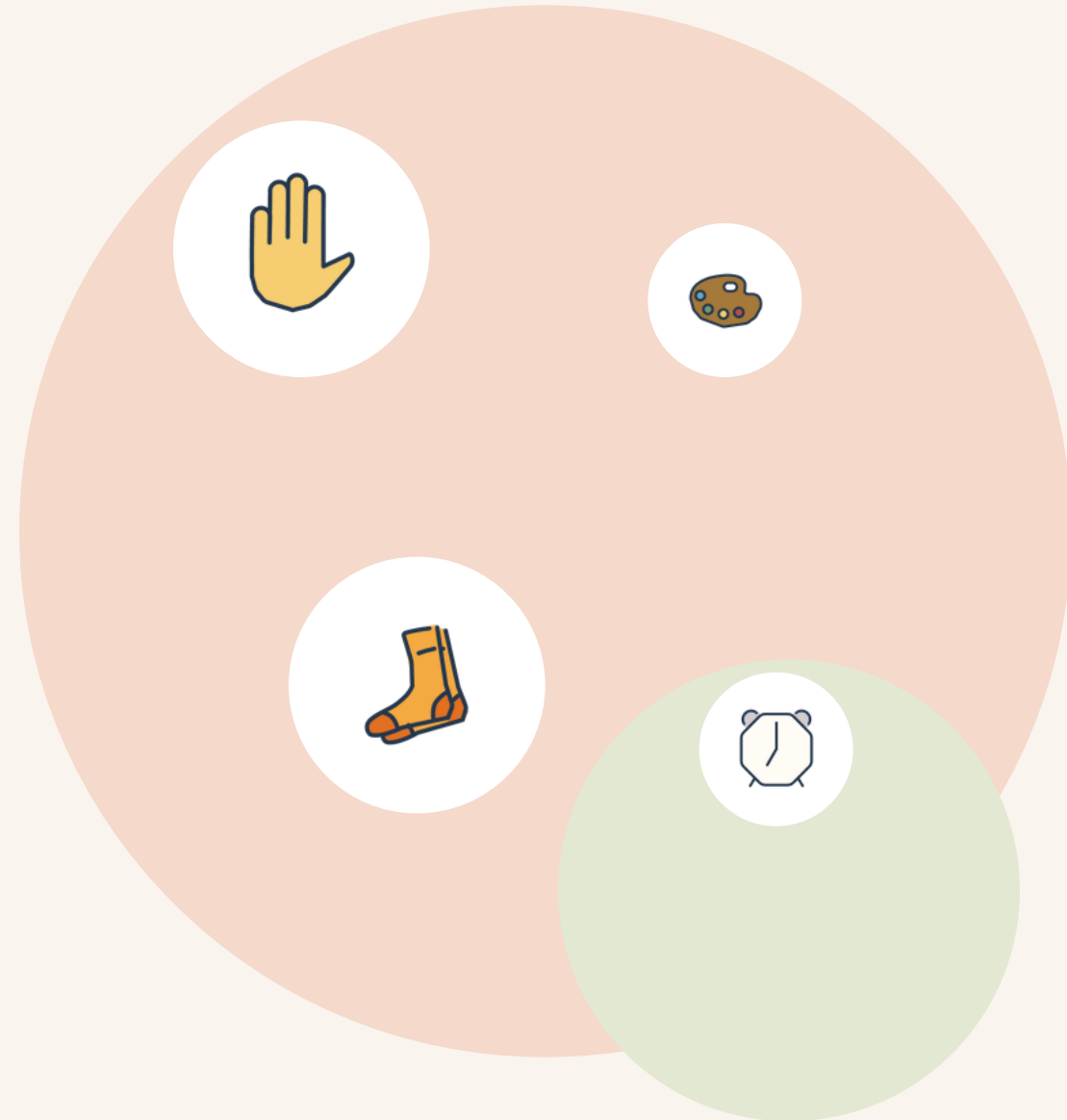


THERAPIST SPOTLIGHT

Occupational Therapy: Making Daily Life Work

How OTs support sensory needs, motor skills and routines for autistic and ADHD kids and adults.



What an OT works on



Sensory processing

Finding comfort with sound, touch, light and movement.



Motor skills

Handwriting, scissors, buttons, balance and coordination.



Daily living

Dressing, eating, hygiene, sleep and morning routines.

Sensory differences are real

- Noise, tags or bright light can feel painful
- Some people seek movement, pressure or chewing
- Overload can look like a meltdown or shutdown
- Stimming often helps a person self-regulate



A sensory diet

A planned set of activities through the day, such as swinging, heavy work or quiet breaks, that keeps the body regulated.

Inside an OT session

1

Check in

How is the body
feeling today?

2

Move

Swings, climbing
or heavy work to
regulate.

3

Practice

A target skill,
built into play.

4

Calm down

Quiet, deep
pressure or
breathing.

5

Take home

One small
strategy for the
week.

Executive-function supports



Visual schedules

Pictures or lists show what comes next and reduce stress.



Visible timers

Make time concrete for starting and switching tasks.



Chunking

Break big tasks into small, finishable steps.



Workspace setup

Fewer distractions, movement options and the right seat.



KEY IDEA

The goal is not to look typical. It's to make daily life comfortable and doable.

Adapting the environment counts as much as building skills.

Questions to ask an OT

- 1 Which sensory or motor needs will you focus on first, and why?
- 2 How will sessions use my child's interests?
- 3 What can we practice at home between sessions?

Look for the credential OTR/L (registered, licensed occupational therapist).